

Freelance Audio Outreach Program

Strategy Document, Playbook & Reference Guide

For: [Your Name / Collective Name] · Version 1.0 · 2025

1. Executive Summary

This document outlines a structured freelance outreach program for a group of 2–4 specialist audio engineers targeting five key market segments: independent musicians and bands, studios and labels, film/TV and advertising agencies, content creators and YouTubers, and local music, film, and game communities.

The program covers brand identity strategy, outreach channels, weekly cadence, lead tracking, objection handling, rate positioning, client onboarding, and a 90-day launch plan. All templates are modular — clearly marked for individual versus collective branding so you can adapt them as your group decides on positioning.

What This Document Covers

- Brand Identity: Collective vs. Individual — a decision framework
- Target Market Profiles — who you're reaching and how to tailor your pitch
- Channel Strategy — ranked by ROI for audio freelancers
- Outreach Cadence — a repeatable weekly workflow
- Lead Tracking System — lightweight CRM approach
- Objection Handling — common pushbacks and how to respond
- Rate Strategy — how to position and quote confidently
- Client Onboarding — from first reply to first invoice
- KPIs and Metrics — what to measure and when
- 90-Day Launch Plan — a week-by-week action roadmap

NOTE

All email templates referenced in this doc are in the companion document: Email Outreach Templates. Use both documents together.

2. Brand Identity: Collective vs. Individual

This is the most important strategic decision you'll make before launching outreach. How you present yourselves affects every email subject line, every portfolio link, every proposal. The good news: you don't have to lock this in forever — but you do need to pick one mode to start with.

Option A: Collective / Studio Brand

You operate under a shared studio name (e.g., "Soundshift Audio" or "Parallel Studios"). All outreach comes from the brand. Individual engineers are presented as the team behind the brand.

Pros

- Projects perceived as more professional and scalable
- Easier to take on large projects that need multiple engineers
- Brand equity accumulates — past work builds a collective reputation
- Can charge higher rates ("studio" vs. "freelancer" positioning)
- Clients feel they're hiring a team, not taking a risk on one person

Cons

- Requires agreement on rates, credit splits, and client ownership rules
- More upfront work: shared portfolio, shared email, shared invoicing approach
- If the collective disbands, brand equity can be lost

Option B: Individual with Cross-Referral

Each engineer operates under their own name, but you have a formal referral arrangement with each other. When one engineer is at capacity or lacks a specific skill, they refer to the group.

Pros

- Lower coordination overhead — each person controls their own business
- Works well if engineers have meaningfully different niches or styles
- No revenue split disputes
- Can still pitch together for large projects on an ad-hoc basis

Cons

- Each person builds reputation independently — slower to establish credibility
- Harder to win large agency/label briefs that want a single point of contact
- Referral trust needs to be earned over time

Recommendation

Start as a Collective with individual profiles visible on the website. This gives you the credibility of a studio while keeping individual personalities and specialisms prominent. Use a shared outreach email (hello@studiobrand.com) but sign emails as individuals to keep it human.

ACTION

Decide on a name and register the domain before sending any outreach. Even a simple landing page is enough to start.

3. Target Market Profiles

Below is a profile for each of your five target segments. Use these to tailor your tone, value proposition, and call-to-action for each outreach campaign.

3.1 Independent Musicians & Bands

Dimension	Profile	Your Hook
Pain Points	Budget uncertainty, home recording quality issues, don't know what to ask for	Transparent pricing, free consult, plain-English process
Decision Driver	Sound quality, trust, and budget certainty	Samples + fixed-fee quotes upfront
Where to Find	Instagram, Facebook groups, local venues, Bandcamp	Direct DM/email + community presence
Best Outreach	Personalised email referencing their music	Lead with a genuine compliment, then value
Avg Project	Single mix (\$300–\$800), EP (\$800–\$2,500)	Offer a loss-leader single to get in the door

3.2 Studios & Labels

Dimension	Profile	Your Hook
Pain Points	Overflow capacity, specialist skills gaps (e.g., game audio, broadcast)	We handle overflow — reliable, fast, no babysitting
Decision Driver	Reliability, technical spec compliance, speed of delivery	Track record, quick turnaround, spec knowledge
Where to Find	LinkedIn, APRA/AMCOS directories, local studio listings	Cold email to studio managers / A&R contacts
Best Outreach	Short, spec-focused email + reel link	Keep it businesslike — they're busy
Avg Project	Session rates (\$80–\$150/hr) or flat project fees	Position as a reliable overflow partner

3.3 Film, TV & Advertising Agencies

Dimension	Profile	Your Hook
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Pain Points	Tight post-production deadlines, managing multiple suppliers	Single-point audio supplier, broadcast-ready delivery
Decision Driver	Credits and reel, turnaround time, broadcast spec compliance	Show R128/LUFS knowledge and real credits
Where to Find	LinkedIn, Screen Australia database, local production company listings	Direct to post supervisors and producers
Best Outreach	Brief, credit-led email with reel and broadcast spec mention	One email + one follow-up, then move on
Avg Project	Short film (\$1,500–\$5,000+), TVC (\$800–\$2,500+)	Highest per-project value — worth pursuing

3.4 Content Creators & YouTubers

Dimension	Profile	Your Hook
Pain Points	Inconsistent audio quality, time-consuming editing, lack of music	We make your content sound as good as it looks
Decision Driver	Price, turnaround, low friction	Subscription/retainer model = recurring revenue
Where to Find	YouTube, TikTok, Instagram, Discord, Creator communities	Direct DM via their preferred platform
Best Outreach	Short, casual email/DM referencing their channel specifically	Be human and direct — no jargon
Avg Project	Ongoing retainer (\$500–\$2,000/month), one-off (\$200–\$600)	Best source of predictable monthly income

3.5 Local Music, Film & Game Communities

Dimension	Profile	Your Hook
Pain Points	Limited local audio resource, especially for niche areas like game audio	We're in Perth and available — no delays, no timezone issues
Decision Driver	Relationships, reputation, local accessibility	Show up, contribute, build trust first
Where to Find	ScreenWest, WAM, Perth game dev meetups, local Facebook groups	Community engagement before selling

Best Outreach	In-person + follow-up email, or community post offering value	Offer a free workshop, Q&A, or portfolio review night
Avg Project	Variable — relationships drive project selection	Long-term: these become your best referral sources

4. Channel Strategy

The following channels are ranked by estimated ROI for audio freelancers. Prioritise the top three to start; add the others as capacity allows.

Channel Rankings

Channel	Why It Works for Audio Freelancers
1. Direct Email (Cold + Warm)	Highest control, personalisation, and response rates. Direct line to decision-makers. Start here.
2. Referrals & Word of Mouth	Best conversion rate of any channel. Comes from doing great work and asking for referrals explicitly.
3. LinkedIn	Best for studios, labels, post houses, and agencies. Not ideal for independent artists.
4. Instagram / SoundCloud / Bandcamp	Best for indie musicians and bands. Show your work, engage with their content first.
5. Local Community Groups	Perth-specific. WAM, ScreenWest, local game dev groups. Slow build, strong return.
6. Discord / Slack Communities	Good for game audio and podcast clients. Niche forums (IndieGameDev, podcast subreddits).
7. YouTube / TikTok Outreach	DMs via creator platforms. Works well for content creator segment. Low barrier.

Channel-Specific Tactics

Email

- Use a custom domain email — never Gmail or Hotmail for cold outreach
- Limit to 3–5 emails per day per person to avoid spam filters
- Always personalise the first line — reference something specific about them
- Use plain text, not HTML, for cold emails (higher deliverability)
- Track opens with a tool like Mailtrack or Streak (free tiers available)

LinkedIn

- Optimise each engineer's profile with a reel link and clear headline
- Post short audio education content (mixing tips, behind-the-scenes) weekly
- Send connection requests with a brief note — no pitch in the first message

- After connecting, wait 3–5 days before introducing your services

Instagram & Social

- Post reel snippets, before/after audio comparisons, and studio photos
- Engage with target artists for 2–3 weeks before sending a DM
- Don't send a pitch in a first DM — start with a genuine compliment or question

Community Engagement

- WAM (West Australian Music): Join mailing list, attend events, sponsor if budget allows
- ScreenWest: Register as a crew member, attend networking events
- Perth Game Dev meetups: Attend regularly, offer to do a 15-min talk on game audio

5. Outreach Cadence & Weekly Workflow

Consistency beats intensity. This cadence is designed to be sustainable for a working audio engineer alongside active projects.

Weekly Outreach Target

Activity	Weekly Target	Notes
Cold emails sent	10–15 per person	Personalised, not bulk-blasted
Follow-ups sent	5–10	Day 4 and Day 10 after cold email
LinkedIn activity	3 posts or comments	Educational or portfolio-based
Community touchpoint	1	Attend event, post in group, reply to forum
Referral asks	1–2	From current/past clients after delivery
Lead tracker update	Weekly (Friday)	Log all activity and responses

Daily Schedule (Outreach Days: Mon, Wed, Fri)

- 8:00–8:30am — Research targets for the day (15 min) + personalise email drafts (15 min)
- 8:30–9:00am — Send emails and LinkedIn messages
- 9:00–9:15am — Reply to any inbound inquiries from previous outreach
- Friday EOD — Update lead tracker, review week, plan next week's targets

Follow-Up Sequence

The follow-up sequence is where most deals are won or lost. Most people don't respond to the first email — that's normal.

Touchpoint	Timing & Action
Email 1 (Cold)	Day 1 — Personalised introduction, value proposition, soft CTA
Email 2 (Follow-up 1)	Day 4–5 — Brief bump, different angle, ask a question
Email 3 (Follow-up 2)	Day 10–12 — Share something useful (article, tip, relevant work)

Email 4 (Final)	Day 18–21 — Polite close: 'Last one from me — happy to connect whenever timing's right'
Move to Dormant List	After Email 4 — Re-engage in 3 months with a new angle

KEY RULE

Never follow up more than 4 times with a non-responder in a single campaign cycle. Persistence is good; harassment kills your reputation.

6. Lead Tracking System

You don't need expensive CRM software. A shared Google Sheet is enough for a team of 2–4 people to start. The key is consistency — update it every week without fail.

Recommended Spreadsheet Structure

Column	What to Record
Contact Name	First name + last name of the person you're reaching out to
Company / Project	Band name, studio, agency, channel name, etc.
Segment	Music / Film & TV / Podcast / Creator / Community
Email / LinkedIn	Contact details (don't store in separate places)
Status	New / Contacted / Follow-up Due / Replied / Proposal Sent / Won / Lost / Dormant
Last Contact Date	Date of most recent touchpoint
Next Action	What to do next and when (e.g., 'Follow-up 2 on 15 Mar')
Notes	Anything that will help personalise future contact
Source	How you found them (Instagram, LinkedIn, referral, event, etc.)
Assigned To	Which engineer owns this lead (relevant for collective)

Pipeline Stage Definitions

- New — Identified but no contact yet
- Contacted — First email / DM sent
- Follow-up Due — In the follow-up sequence
- Replied — They've responded (positive, neutral, or 'not now')
- Proposal Sent — You've sent a quote or scope of work
- Won — Project confirmed / deposit received
- Lost — Explicitly declined or went with someone else
- Dormant — No response after full sequence; re-engage in 3 months

Upgrade Path

Once you have 50+ active leads or 3+ active clients, consider upgrading to a lightweight CRM like HubSpot Free, Notion CRM template, or Airtable. These offer reminders, pipeline views, and better filtering.

7. Objection Handling Guide

These are the most common objections you'll encounter and suggested responses. Adapt the tone to your voice — the goal is to keep the conversation open without being pushy.

Objection	Suggested Response
"We have someone in-house."	"Totally makes sense. If you ever have a crunch or need a specific skill (like game audio or broadcast delivery), happy to be your first call. Can I send across a quick overview?"
"We don't have the budget right now."	"No worries at all — audio can be expensive. Would it help to know our starting rates so you can keep us in mind when budget frees up? We also do phased payment plans."
"Send me your rates."	"Happy to — though my rates vary by project type. Could I ask a couple of quick questions first so I can give you a realistic number rather than a generic range?"
"We already have an engineer we use."	"Great — good engineers are hard to find! If you ever need someone for overflow or a project that needs a different set of ears, keep us in mind. Happy to stay in touch."
"I'll let you know when something comes up."	"Of course — no pressure at all. Is it OK if I check in once a quarter? I don't want to be a pest, just want to be top of mind when the time is right."
"I don't know if we can afford professional mixing."	"I get it — it's a real investment. Would it be worth doing a test mix of one track? You can hear the difference before committing to a full project. I can do that for \$[X]."

8. Rate & Pricing Strategy

Pricing is one of the hardest parts of freelancing. The goal is to charge what you're worth, be consistent across the team, and make it easy for clients to say yes. Here is a framework to help you do that.

Pricing Principles

- Always quote in writing. Verbal agreements lead to scope creep.
- Use project-based fees wherever possible, not hourly rates — clients hate open-ended billing.
- Have a minimum engagement rate. Avoid sub-\$250 projects; they cost more in admin than they earn.
- Never discount without reducing scope. Discounting without reducing deliverables trains clients to negotiate.
- Build in revision rounds explicitly. '3 rounds of revisions' is better than 'until you're happy' (which is never).

Suggested Rate Ranges

The following are broad Australian market ranges for indie/mid-tier work. Research local market rates and adjust based on your experience level.

Service	Entry Level	Experienced
Single mix	\$150–\$300	\$400–\$800+
Album mix (10 tracks)	\$1,200–\$2,500	\$3,500–\$7,000+
Mastering (per track)	\$60–\$150	\$150–\$350
Short film audio post (<20min)	\$800–\$1,500	\$2,000–\$5,000+
TVC audio (30sec)	\$400–\$800	\$800–\$2,500+
Podcast episode edit	\$80–\$150	\$150–\$300
Podcast production (ongoing)	\$600–\$1,200/mo	\$1,500–\$3,500/mo
Game audio SFX library	\$500–\$2,000	\$2,500–\$10,000+

Voice-over recording + edit	\$150–\$400	\$400–\$1,000
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Quoting Process

1. Receive brief or initial inquiry
2. Ask clarifying questions (track count, runtime, reference tracks, deadline, delivery format)
3. Prepare written quote within 24 hours
4. Quote includes: scope, deliverables, revision rounds, timeline, payment terms
5. Request 50% deposit to lock in the booking
6. Begin work only after deposit is received

Payment Terms

- 50% deposit upfront, 50% on final delivery
- Payment via bank transfer or Stripe/Square
- Late payment: 5% per 14 days after due date (state this in your quote)
- For retainer clients: monthly invoice, paid in advance

9. Client Onboarding Process

A smooth onboarding experience sets the tone for the entire project. Do this consistently and clients will feel confident they made the right choice.

Onboarding Checklist

Step	Action
1. Confirm Booking	Send confirmation email with project summary, timeline, and payment link for deposit
2. Send Client Brief Form	Google Form or PDF asking for reference tracks, notes file, preferred delivery format, and any special requirements
3. Receive Files	Confirm receipt of all source files; flag any issues (sample rate mismatches, missing tracks, noise issues)
4. Kick-off Message	Short message: 'Got everything, starting [date], first draft by [date]'
5. First Revision Delivery	Send work-in-progress file with a brief note on your decisions. Ask for specific feedback, not general impressions.
6. Revisions	Address feedback clearly; confirm when revision round is complete
7. Final Delivery	Send all final files with a delivery note: format, loudness standard, naming convention
8. Invoice	Send final invoice on delivery of files; thank client by name
9. Follow-up (7 days later)	Check in: 'How did the release go?' — this is when to ask for a testimonial or referral

PRO TIP

Create a shared Dropbox or Google Drive folder for every client. Label it clearly. Clients love being able to access their files independently and it reduces back-and-forth emails.

10. KPIs & Success Metrics

Track these monthly. Numbers only matter if you review them and act on them.

Metric	What It Tells You
Emails sent per month	Input volume — are you actually doing the outreach?
Email open rate	Is your subject line working? (Aim: >40% for cold email)
Reply rate	Is your copy working? (Aim: >8% cold, >20% warm)
Proposals sent per month	How many conversations are converting to serious interest?
Proposal win rate	Is your pricing and pitch working? (Aim: >30%)
Revenue from new clients	Is the outreach driving real income?
Revenue from repeat clients	Are you delivering well enough to earn repeat business?
Referrals received	Are clients happy enough to recommend you?
Average project value	Are you moving up-market over time?
Time-to-quote	Are you responding fast enough? (Aim: <24 hours)

Monthly Review Questions

- Which segment generated the most inquiries this month?
- Which channel drove the highest quality leads?
- Which engineer has the best proposal win rate? What are they doing differently?
- What objection came up most often this month? How can we address it in our emails?
- Are we at capacity? If so, should we raise our rates?

11. 90-Day Launch Plan

Use this as your launch roadmap. Weeks are indicative — adjust to your existing workload.

Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1–3)

- Decide on collective vs. individual branding and confirm all team members agree
- Secure domain name and create a minimal website (even a one-pager with a contact form)
- Set up shared outreach email (e.g., hello@yourstudio.com.au)
- Build a portfolio page with 3–5 work samples across your service areas
- Set up the lead tracking spreadsheet and share with the team
- Each engineer writes a short (3 para) bio for the website
- Finalise your rate card and minimum engagement fee
- Identify 50 initial outreach targets (10 per segment)

Phase 2: Warm-Up (Weeks 4–6)

- Begin following and engaging with targets on Instagram / LinkedIn before emailing
- Attend one local community event (WAM, ScreenWest, game dev meetup)
- Send first 15 cold emails using the templates (5 per segment initially)
- Post first piece of content on LinkedIn and Instagram (a before/after, tip, or case study)
- Ask 3 past clients for a short testimonial
- Get at least one referral request out to a trusted contact

Phase 3: Active Outreach (Weeks 7–12)

- Scale to 10–15 emails per week per engineer
- Follow-up cadence running for all active leads
- Review metrics at end of Week 8 — adjust copy or targeting if reply rate < 5%
- Aim to have sent 100+ emails by end of Week 10
- Target: 2–3 paid projects booked by end of Week 12
- After first 5 projects: review rate card. Are you leaving money on the table?
- After 10 projects: consider your first testimonial/case study page on the website

**SUCCESS
BENCHMARK**

By the end of 90 days: 150+ emails sent, 8–15% reply rate, 3+ projects booked, at least 1 retainer client in discussion. If you're below this, review your email copy and target list quality before adding volume.